

# **Lab Notebook & Assignment Proposal - Week 1 & 2**

## **Bureaucracy and Authority**

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### **Goals for this week's lab notebook**

- Review the syllabus
- Catch up on readings for week 1 and week 2
- Pick an agency for policy lab assignments
- Write a proposal for individual policy lab assignments (due Tuesday)

### **Questions in the first class**

#### **Q1. What does bureaucracy mean to me?**

Bureaucracy to me refers to bridges that connect the society and the government, facilitating the implementation of policies and services.

#### **Q2. What's my hope we don't do in this lab?**

My hope is that we don't just focus on the theoretical aspects of bureaucracy, but also explore its practical implications and real-world applications across the states.

I do hope to develop my research puzzles and my current paper during this class.

## Agency Choice: Social Security Administration (SSA)

- Agency choice
  - what they do as a public?
  - what is it you like
  - look at the sourcebook
  - have they been active?
  - missions public
  - can see the budget
  - sth super interesting about them
    - \* is there a huge controversy?
    - \* big missions
    - \* somehow interact with intergovernment footprint? or locality?
  - who it is.. what is our expectation following the policy lab

### What does SSA do for the public?

The Social Security Administration (SSA) is a federal agency that provides crucial services to Americans, including retirement, disability, and survivors benefits. It plays a vital role in the social safety net by ensuring that eligible individuals receive the financial support they need during times of retirement, disability, or loss of a family member.

## Policy Lab Plan

### Proposal for Policy Lab Assignments

- Pam: look at learning objectives; policy labs; and write what would I do to meet the same targets at the phd level research

Learning objectives:

- To understand how bureaucratic theories explain contemporary public administration challenges
- To critically evaluate the role of bureaucratic structures in policy implementation and democratic governance
- To synthesize theoretical perspectives with current events through AI-assisted analysis
- To apply ethical frameworks to complex public administration problems
- To display the ability to apply ethics to a public problem
- To develop original arguments that build upon AI-generated insights while demonstrating independent critical thinking

### How I would meet the learning objectives

My main goal from this course is to dig into bureaucratic theories and their application to contemporary public administration challenges, particularly in the context of the Social Security Administration (SSA). I plan to develop my current working papers from this class, which are titled:

- *Efficiency for Whom? The Politics of SSA Field Office Closings and Racialized Administrative Burden*
- *Amplification or Insulation? The Role of Agency Ideology in Donation-Linked Favoritism in U.S. Federal Contracting.*

Particularly, I want to focus on:

- What are the key bureaucratic theories that can help explain the dynamics of policy implementation and administrative decisions within SSA, which can be relevant to understanding the agency's ideology or administrative burdens?
- The role of agency ideology in shaping policy implementation, administrative decisions, and intergovernmental footprint within SSA
- Relationships between agency ideology and the broader political and social context in which SSA operates
- Bureaucratic structures and processes within SSA that contribute to contracting practices
- Relevant Datasets available to study these dynamics and produce figures and tables for analysis

## Policy Lab 1. Agency Profile Briefer (10%) - Due Sep 13

- Choose a federal agency whose structure, authority, or administration raises a pressing question of bureaucratic design
- 3-page team brief (single-spaced) that profiles the agency:
  - Statutory mission and Authority
    - \* go into authorized statutes (from their website: our authority comes from ...)
    - \* authorized statute (at least a sample of some of them)
  - Organizational Structure
    - \* overview of the agency's internal structure, including major divisions and offices
  - Degree of Independence
    - \* the sourcebook has its info
    - \* their website
  - Why Understanding It Matters Now
- Appendices:
  1. An annotated bibliography
    - A list of key sources
    - books about federal agencies; journal articles; policy papers
    - presidential reports to the Congress
    - Pam is a fan of peer reviews: peer-reviewed journal articles are preferred
    - elements I'm thinking about to include: research question, gaps/conflicts in the literature, argument, key findings, data, methodology, and conclusions
      - \* what I'm using it for, what's in it, and how it contributes to my understanding of the topic (don't have to be long)
  2. An organization/authority diagram (a visual depiction of the agency's structure and its relationship to Congress, the President, and the courts)
    - Sanford and Moulton provide guidance on creating a policy field diagram
  3. A stakeholder analysis identifying the agency's key constituencies and oversight actors
    - stakeholder analysis: look up Sanford and Moulton
- Prepare for a short team lightning talk (5-7 minutes in class on Sep 17)

## Policy Lab 1: Proposal

While keeping the current structure, add findings/gaps from recent literature to the “why understanding it matters now” part.

## Policy Lab 2. Intergovernmental Footprint (15%) – Due October 18

- Conduct a team-based analysis of how your agency's programs, rules, grants, or enforcement authority interact with state, local, tribal, or territorial governments (SLTTGs) in a minimum of three states or jurisdictions.
- Identify:
  - the relevant statutes and intergovernmental mechanisms at play (e.g., grants, delegated authority, cooperative agreements, preemption)
  - the politics shaping variation across jurisdictions; any relevant federal-state litigation, disputes, or friction points
  - the evidence base for how well the arrangement is working.
- Diagram the logic of your agency's intergovernmental relationships and link variation across jurisdictions to that logic.
- Your written report should be approximately 3,000–4,000 words plus your integrative diagram, submitted via Canvas by 11:59 PM on Sunday, October 18.
- Present your findings as a short team talk (10–12 minutes) in class on November 5, followed by peer feedback.

## Policy Lab 2: Proposal

- While keeping the current structure, add potential research questions or topics to my SSA's intergovernmental footprint summary.
- Write reasonings based on relevant literature, such as:
  - Clouser McCann (2015), The strategic use of congressional intergovernmental delegation. *The Journal of Politics*, 77(3), 620-634.
  - Watkins-Hayes (2011), Race, respect, and red tape: Inside the black box of racially representative bureaucracies. *Journal of Public Administration Research and Theory*, 21(suppl\_2), i233-i251.
- Since I will have a paper presentation at the APPAM conference, I will not be able to make the presentation in class on November 5; however, I would love to have some peer feedback on my written report, if possible.

## Policy Lab 3. Policy Lab #3: Implementation Practicum (10%) – In class November 12

- With your project team, apply implementation theory to your agency and one of its key rules or programs:

1. Forward map the policy through its implementation using top-down models (problem definition, implementer capacity, consensus and conflict, external factors)
  2. Backward map from street level to policy design using bottom-up models (targets, administrators, choices and incentives, context and learning)
  3. Analyze the roles of ambiguity, discretion, goal congruence, autonomy, oversight, conflict, power, and resources as they apply to your agency.
- Each team member leads one segment (about 10 minutes) using words, bullet points, and diagrams.
  - Team materials are submitted at the end of class. Strategic students will use this session as preparation for their mock testimonies

### **Policy Lab 3: Proposal**

While keeping the current structure, provide potential data sources and empirical strategies that can help conduct relevant analysis for part 3.

### **Individual Congressional Testimony: Mock Hearing (10%) – In class November 19**

- Individually, investigate how your agency has reported to Congress: identify relevant oversight hearings, committee reports, GAO reports, or agency testimony from recent years.
- In class, each team member delivers individual mock testimony (approximately 5 minutes) as if appearing before a congressional oversight hearing, while classmates role-play members of Congress and pose followup questions.
- Submit a short written statement (1–2 pages) summarizing your testimony and citing your sources via Canvas before class.
- This is an individual assignment; coordinate with your team to avoid duplicating one another's testimony.

### **Individual Congressional Testimony: Proposal - Text Analysis or Literature Review**

- **Option 1:** Text Analysis on Congressional Testimony: Conduct text analysis on SSA's oversight hearings, committee reports, GAO reports, or agency testimony from the past 5 years. Provide findings from the text analysis with figures and their interpretations.
- **Option 2:** Literature Review on relationships between SSA policy outcomes/contracting/budgets and Congress

### **Final Project: Federal Agency Documentary (25%)**

- The capstone of the course is a team documentary video profiling your project team's federal agency – the culmination of your labs and notebook work synthesized into a single narrative and visual analysis. Videos should be recorded using accessible tools (smartphone video, Zoom, Canvas Studio, or similar) and uploaded with captions for accessibility. The project has the following components:
  - Draft & Peer Review Workshop (included in participation): upload a rough-cut video (6–10 minutes, roughly 70–80% complete) by 5:00 PM on December 3; complete structured peer reviews using the provided rubric by December 7.
  - In-Class Screening (included in participation): screen your near-final cut in class on December 10 for whole-class discussion and feedback.
  - Documentary Video (15%): final polished cut (8–12 minutes), in an explainer-documentary style, covering your agency's statutory structure and authority, budget, oversight and litigation exposure, and a current controversy or case study. Due via Canvas by 5:00 PM on December 17 (finals week).
  - Written Dossier (10%): a 5–8 page team document with an annotated bibliography, sourcing notes for claims made in the video, and a brief written synthesis connecting your findings to course concepts (delegation, rulemaking, budgeting, oversight, and inter-governmental relations). Due alongside the video, with an AI collaboration statement.

### **Final Project. Proposal - Research Updates or Proposal**

- **Option 1:** Summary of Working Paper Revisions: Based on the proposed assignments,
  1. Write an approximately 2-3 page summary of how each assignment helps revise current working papers
  2. Provide an updated version of the working paper or presentation slides, related to SSA
- **Option 2:** Research Proposal: Based on the proposed assignments above, write a research proposal that includes:
  - Introduction
  - Theoretical framework
  - Empirical strategy
  - Conclusion

## **Week 2 Reading Notes**

**Weber (1921)**

**Sandfort & Moulton (2015)**

**Federal News Network (2026)**

## References

- Clouser McCann, P. J. (2015). The strategic use of congressional intergovernmental delegation. *The Journal of Politics*, 77(3), 620–634.
- Watkins-Hayes, C. (2011). Race, respect, and red tape: Inside the black box of racially representative bureaucracies. *Journal of Public Administration Research and Theory*, 21(suppl\_2), i233–i251.